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Review

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BIBLIOGRAPHIE/BOOK REVIEWS

Ronald C. EGAN, *Word, Image, and Deed in the Life of Su Shi*, Harvard-Yenching Institute Monograph Series 39. Cambridge: Council on East Asian Studies, Harvard University, 1994. xix + 474 pp. Notes, Bibliography, Chinese Title Index, Glossary-Index, Illustrations.

I believe any person with an interest in China should study this book. Indeed, anyone who deals with the humanities at large would profit by reading *Word, Image, and Deed*, for it exemplifies a subtlety and clarity of thought and expression rare in any age and especially lacking in recent writing on literature and culture.

Let us assume that the readers of this journal, however, constitute a smaller audience that knows something about China and has a sense of the importance of Su Shih (1037–1101) either as a literary figure and cultural icon or as an influential critic of the New Policies that sought to redefine the economic role of the state at a pivotal juncture in Chinese history. We all know *something* about Su Shih, just as we know something about Lu Hsün, Tseng Kuo-fan, Han Yü, and Ts'ao Ts'ao. What is it about this book that makes it so important that we take this opportunity to learn more about this man, regardless of our discipline or period of interest?

To begin with, there is the sheer greatness of the man. Now, I frankly am tired of being told what a multifaceted genius Su Shih was, though I suppose this telling is an important ritual for our colleagues in China who need to promote him as a cultural hero. Egan's Western audience is not looking for national icons, so he can spare us the pieties. Yet I find that in the process of comprehensively explicating the intellectual and political environment of Su Shih, the values he formulated in response to the challenges of that environment, and the ways in which his responses are reflected in his writings, Egan indirectly renews and deepens our appreciation of what can only be summed up as Su Shih's greatness.

Su Shih emerges in this book as a model of caring engagement with the world. Chapter 5, "Provincial Activism In and Out of Office," for example, reveals the energy and creativity Su Shih exer-

cised in wheedling funds out of the government to address local issues. Historians will find in this chapter a detailed, well-documented, and very readable account of his famine relief efforts in Hang-chou (1089–91), as well as descriptions of his campaigns for debt abatement, flood control, military housing, and medical care for prisoners and commoners. Even when he lived in exile, stripped of official authority and salary, Su Shih exerted himself to reduce infanticide, to build bridges, and to improve water supply and (again) military housing. In this he relied on his ability to persuade others to take action, for he himself was forbidden to concern himself with public affairs. Such covert activism on the part of a reviled exile had virtually no precedent in Chinese history and no supporting ideology in Confucian or Taoist traditions (see pp. 127 and 132–33). It also, I would observe, shows another arena in which Su Shih's production of texts is a significant and effective part of his engagement with the world: he brings astonishing intellectual vigor to the task of articulating in language both the larger meaning of that engagement and the practical details of carrying it out. (Note that much of our evidence for his activities is based on the letters he wrote to cajole others.)

Egan prepares the way for this chapter in a series of enlightening discussions on Su Shih's opposition to the New Policies, tracing his evolving thought from early essays through the protest poetry of the seventies that nearly resulted in his execution. Due attention and clear explication is given to Su Shih's commentaries on the *Book of Changes* and *Book of Documents*, begun in the 1080's and reworked during the last half-decade of his life. These commentaries reveal the attitudes that underlay both his political philosophy and his cultural activities. While some contemporaries may have striven for a more fully developed view of the inner nature of man, Su Shih had more to say about the interaction between self and world. "[P]robably the most original aspect of Su's interpretation of the" *Changes* is his affirmation "that the superior man will never permit himself to be solitary or aloof from the world in which he lives" (p. 76). Su Shih thought carefully about how one should engage with the world: he

was not completely satisfied with "freedom from selfishness." ... [H]e sought to replace it in his commentary on the *Changes* with a more radical notion of selflessness. Another phrase (used interchangeably with no-mind) helps to clarify Su's notion. He says that the sage has no intent (*wuyi*) towards things. He evidently means that 1) the person should have no ulterior motives, 2) he should

have no preconceived notions about the nature of those things or how best to react to them (that is supposed to be determined on the spur of the moment by the shape of the things encountered), and 3) he should shed all sense of self in his dealings with things (p. 82).

Egan shows how such views are integrally tied in with Su's experience with and critique of the New Policies: the New Policies were harmful because Wang An-shih's philosophy of inward-turning quietude encouraged disengagement from the consequences of his radical new programs; worse, preconceptions of how the world works were defended fiercely while no one took responsibility for the actual results of putting those preconceptions into practice.

An extremely important contribution to our understanding of Su Shih is found in Chapter 6, "A Thousand Arms and Eyes: Buddhist Influences." "So numerous and varied were Su Shi[h]'s humane initiatives," Egan observes, "that it may be easy to overlook one goal that the majority of them share: the saving of life" (p. 137). Egan does not hold that Buddhism was the only influence on Su Shih's activities, but he notes that it is one we can clearly document through his writings—as he proceeds to do. Compassion, selflessness, and non-attachment, themes that pervade Su Shih's life and writings, are shown to have specific Buddhist formulations that he drew on to convey his values to others. At the same time, Egan is careful to point out, Su Shih had "lingering reservations" about Buddhist beliefs and practices that led to disengagement from the world.

Turning to Su Shih's *shih* poetry, Egan masterfully surveys the significant aspects of his art: Su's use of jocularly, interest in unusual perspectives (literal or social), reflections on transitory moments, and fondness for unusual metaphors are insightfully characterized as his attempts to "replicate with words such feats as the bodhisattvas could accomplish, collapsing the normal dimensions of space and time, or otherwise offering up novel ways of envisioning familiar events or things" (p. 197). In a finely nuanced discussion of the problem of reconciling poetry's foundation in the emotions with Su Shih's aversion to self-centered indulgence in emotion, Egan shows how the poet performed a balancing act in his poetry: acknowledging emotional ties to the world (especially to his younger brother) while yet questioning the status of the self.

A separate chapter on the literature of Su Shih's exile periods shows how great an effort must have gone into his creation of the

poetic personae of the humble farmer (on the model of T'ao Ch'ien but resolutely more serene than T'ao, despite having fallen to lower depths from loftier station) or the "native" of Hainan (a pleasant setting for the Eighth Conference on Su Shih this reviewer attended in July 1995, but in the eleventh century so remote that Chinese culture still had barely a toehold on the island). This chapter includes an enlightening exposition of the second Red Cliff Rhapsody as emblematic of Su's impulses to pursue Taoist paths to immortality and his "doubts—not so much about immortality as about his own suitability for the task" (p. 250). Finally, there is this important and, to me, very moving conclusion to a section on the element of defiance in Su Shih's exile poetry:

Once poetry became for him not only a source of consolation, giving proof that he really could find contentment in obscurity, but also a way of showing that his spirit and outrage over what had befallen him were undiminished, he had to keep writing. To stop would have been tacitly to admit either that he no longer saw any injustice or that he no longer dared call attention to it. This particular motive for writing poetry bears some resemblance to the reasons Su had for returning to his commentaries on the classics whenever he was sent into exile. For all their obvious differences, and despite the ways in which both transcend the politics of the day, both types of writing are informed at one level by Su's resolve to keep answering back against the persons and policies that sent him into exile (p. 260).

In his discussion of Su Shih's views on calligraphy, Egan explores ways in which he modified the moralistic connection between man and style emphasized by his mentor, Ou-yang Hsiu.¹ Su Shih raised the possibility that the values we read into a specimen of calligraphy are merely our preconceptions of the calligrapher's moral character. Unsure of how to resolve that question, he managed to salvage the relationship between artist and art by stressing the artist's personality ("spirit"; "manner"; etc.) over the moral significance of his deeds in society as the quality that is re-

¹ Egan's chapter and an important recent article by Amy McNair that treats a larger time-frame may profitably be read in conjunction with each other. McNair associates the views of Ou-yang and his fellow reformers with a campaign to counter the imperially sponsored Two Wangs styles; in view of what Egan says about Su Shih's views, it is ironic to note that in the Southern Sung the moral character of the artist became an important factor in the compilation of rubbings—especially of Su Shih's calligraphy. See "The Engraved Model-Letters Compendia of the Song Dynasty," *JAOS* 114:2 (April-June 1994), 209-25.

vealed through his calligraphy (pp. 267–68). This is another instance, I should think, of Su's preference for stressing the root or origin of phenomena rather than the phenomena themselves. Egan's discussion (pp. 272–73) of the sense of *i* in Su Shih's use of *hsin-i* ("new artistic intent/aesthetic mood") as a nonemotive term of praise in art should be required reading for anyone who deals with aesthetic criticism in Chinese.

The perspicacity of Egan's reading of Su Shih is exhibited once again in the pages where he discusses motivations for Su's interests in the arts. Clearly aware that through these interests he and his fellows had exceeded all predecessors, Su nevertheless only tentatively and in very specific circumstances suggested that the arts were a means by which one might apprehend *li* ("Pattern") or the Way; stronger was his affirmation of the arts as exercises in the expression of self and, to be sure, of unique moral superiority—exercises that were also safer politically than writing (pp. 300–305).

Indeed, it may be the need to express oneself in genres safe from the scrutiny of one's enemies that led Su Shih to pour his energies into *tz'u* during his Huang-chou exile and in the process make the lyric a new vehicle for self-revelation (Chapter 10). With few expectations of seriousness, the genre was also well-suited for projecting the image of a spontaneous and carefree life; yet Egan shows how the other side of the exile's freedom—forlorn rootlessness—may be glimpsed in the Huang-chou lyrics. While others have noted the political or psychological reasons for Su's turning to *tz'u* in exile,² no one to my knowledge has gone on to explore matters of form, style, and intent with the subtlety and breadth shown in this chapter.

I approached the "Conclusions" chapter of *Word, Image, and Deed* with some misgivings, for it begins with Su Shih's posthumous reputation. Too many books on Chinese poets begin or end with ritual citations of the assessments of traditional critics, and I felt it would be a shameful dilution of Egan's masterful analysis to lard it with what, in so few remaining pages, could only be a su-

² For example, in a paper prepared for the 1995 Eighth Conference on Su Shih, Wang Chao-p'eng 王兆鵬 of Hubei University comes up with many of the same reasons as Egan to explain why only 7% (170 poems) of Su's datable *shih* can be ascribed to his Huang-chou period while fully 26% (64 lyrics) of his datable *tz'u* come from the same exile. (Egan gives similar statistics on p. 426, n.41.)

perfunctory summary of Su Shih's place in literary history; moreover, I did not share Egan's confidence (p. 357) that Su Shih's close friends would not stray far, in representing his life, from Su's own views, for I have long felt that Huang T'ing-chien and the others were strong personalities whose appropriations of Su Shih were colored by their own agendas. I need not have worried. Egan makes good use of these early accounts of Su Shih to expose Chu Hsi's later misprisions; and this is in turn only a launching point for revisiting big issues adumbrated in the previous chapters: "Ambivalence over Aesthetic Pursuits"; "The Meanings of *Wen*"; and "The Utility of a Multidimensional View", to cite Egan's sub-headings. Providing an important corrective to general scholarship on Su Shih, Egan demonstrates that Su's self-image and his literary legacy are not always consistent, nor does Su equate all forms of aesthetic expression, as his later admirers (and detractors such as Chu Hsi) are apt to do. Particularly crucial is Su's view that truly significant *wen* means public writing in the realm of ideas and policies. For him, the *wen-jen*, a term only later connoting pure devotion to refined literature and the arts, was epitomized in the person of Lu Chih (754–805), a decidedly non-literary figure (in our view) whose interest, Su wrote, "is in applications to improve the world," and who "does not seek to offer pleasing appearances to the eye and ear" (p. 374).

This concluding chapter reminds us that while we shall always appreciate Su Shih's accomplishments in the many realms in which he distinguished himself, we cannot reduce those accomplishments to a one-dimensional and internally consistent image. To do so would be to reveal our inattention to the tensions between different texts in his legacy; it would indeed also deny Su Shih "some degree of the complexity, multidimensionality, or even contradictoriness that we readily accept in our own lives" (p. 369).

If a reviewer is obligated to offer corrections, mine can only be minor. "What manner of men were they?" in the quotation on p. 239 is not a question but an admiring exclamation and should be punctuated as such. For the line "It was fated once to appear upon the person of a minister of state" (p. 259), I suggest "I once appeared in the person of a minister of state." The character for "bamboo" in the second line of the Chinese text of the other poem on this page is misprinted. On page 282, "Gu Hukou" should be "Gu Hutou." Lines 16–17 of the lyric on p. 343 should

probably be translated “*It is said* on the Five Lakes that / He sailed off in a small boat,” rather than “*He heard the Way* on Five Lakes, / Sailed off in a small boat.” The last line might mean “It was all more or less because of this” rather than “All was more or less the same.” Finally, A.R. Davis’ article “Su Shih’s ‘Following the Rhymes of T’ao Yuan-ming’s Poems’” was published in 1975, not 1974.

In conclusion, I would like to say that Su Shih’s praise for Yen Chen-ch’ing’s calligraphy, quoted on p. 275, can fittingly be applied to Egan’s work, which builds on the best of all previous scholarship on Su Shih to achieve a more comprehensive and finely nuanced new vision: Egan’s book is “robust, elegant, and entirely his own. All at once it transformed all earlier models, just as [Tu Fu’s] poetry did.”

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Anne CHAYET, *Art et Archéologie du Tibet*, Manuels d’Archéologie d’Extrême-Orient sous la direction générale de Henri Hierche, Civilisations de l’Himālaya sous la direction de Alexander W. Macdonald. Paris: Éditions Picard, 1994. 247 pp. Illustrations (photos, dessins, cartes), 4 Annexes, Bibliographie, Index.

Vingt ans après, voici un ouvrage qui semble faire écho au *Tibet* que G. Tucci publiait en français, également dans une collection d’archéologie¹; mais, pour mesurer le chemin parcouru, il suffit de se reporter à l’introduction, où Tucci affirmait que l’archéologie tibétaine était encore “dans les limbes” et que, à sa connaissance, aucune recherche archéologique systématique n’avait été faite au Tibet par les archéologues chinois. En réalité, des fouilles avaient été entreprises dès cette époque, mais c’est à partir des années quatre-vingt qu’elles furent menées sur une plus grande échelle, désormais avec la participation d’archéologues tibétains formés en Chine, et leurs résultats publiés, le plus souvent en chinois, plus rarement en tibétain, ce qui explique leur faible diffusion en Occident. D’emblée, il faut donc remercier A. Chayet d’avoir dépouillé et analysé la littérature spécialisée parue dans

¹ G. Tucci, *Tibet*, traduit de l’italien par Jean Marcadé, Archaeologia Mundi, Genève: éditions Nagel, 1973.